

Stop Using One AI for Everything

Picking one AI and using it for everything is the biggest mistake people make today. The best tool for code is not the best for images, and the app you were told is “for research” is one of the weakest here. This is not opinion. **It is millions of blind head-to-head votes:** two anonymous AIs answer the same prompt, a real person picks the winner, nobody sees the logo.

BAD The weakest of the three for this job. Often still fine overall.	GOOD A strong, dependable pick. Usually the value choice.	GREAT What to reach for first for this job.
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// how to read this **MODEL MATCHUP** = three AIs ranked head-to-head by votes (the number is its rank). **TOOL STACK** = three ways to do a job, weakest to strongest – the winning approach is powered by the top-ranked models.

THE QUICK PICKS

Brainstorming	Claude	Research	Claude + search
Coding	Claude Code	Automating	Make or an agent
Image generation	ChatGPT	Building apps	Claude Code
Learning	NotebookLM		

Brainstorming

MODEL MATCHUP

BAD ChatGPT rank #11 of 378	GOOD Gemini rank #8	GREAT Claude rank #1
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Claude wins the most blind head-to-heads for open-ended thinking. ChatGPT at #11 of 378 is still top 3%, so “bad” only means third of these three. **TRY** Ask for ten angles, then tell it to argue against its own three favorites.

Research

MODEL MATCHUP

BAD Perplexity rank #27	GOOD Gemini rank #7	GREAT Claude rank #1 • 112k votes
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The app most associated with research ranks #27 on blind search tests. Its interface is great; its underlying model loses to Claude and grounded Google search. **TRY** Use a search-enabled Claude and open the citations. No source to click means unverified.

Coding

TOOL STACK

BAD

Replit

browser IDE

GOOD

Cursor

AI code editor

GREAT

Claude Code

agentic coding

The editor is the vehicle; the model inside decides the outcome. Claude is the #2 model of 101 for building real interfaces — the top consumer brand — and an agentic tool lets it read files, run code, and fix its own errors. **TRY** Stop pasting code into a chat box. Use a tool that opens your whole project.

Automating tasks

TOOL STACK

BAD

Shortcuts

rigid macros

GOOD

Make

visual workflows

GREAT

Manus

autonomous agent

Rigid “if this, then that” macros break when reality shifts; an autonomous agent plans and adapts. Agents win because they run frontier models — Claude (#1) and ChatGPT (#2) lead the agent board — and Manus is the most capable off-the-shelf one. **TRY** Make for rigid recurring chores; an agent when the task needs judgment.

Image generation

MODEL MATCHUP

BAD

Canva

layout tool

GOOD

Gemini

Nano Banana · #5

GREAT

ChatGPT

rank #1 · 60k votes

The plot twist: OpenAI’s image model is the actual #1 right now. Google’s hyped Nano Banana is good at #5, but the ranking most people guess is upside down. Canva is a layout tool, not a generator. **TRY** Create in ChatGPT, then move the final image into Canva for text and layout.

Building apps & sites

TOOL STACK

BAD

Squarespace

site templates

GOOD

Lovable

one-shot builder

GREAT

Claude Code

agentic coding

Templates suit a brochure; one-shot builders suit a fast prototype. For something you keep changing, the same #2-of-101 coding model in an agentic tool is strongest. **TRY** Prototype in Lovable tonight, rebuild what survives with Claude. Do not ship the prototype.

Learning a new skill

TOOL STACK

BAD

ChatGPT

general chat

GOOD

Gemini

strong generalist

GREAT

NotebookLM

study from your sources

Purpose beats raw power. For open questions Claude and Gemini lead the general board, but to learn a specific body of material, NotebookLM answers only from your sources, with citations you can check. **TRY** Drop in your notes or a PDF and have it quiz you. Verify its citations against the source.

THE ONE HABIT THAT BEATS ANY TOOL

The people getting real value out of AI are not using a secret app. They use the right app for each task and switch without loyalty. When you catch yourself opening the same tab for everything, that is the tell.

THE ONE RULE

Match the tool to the job, not your habit.

Every rank here is a **26 July 2026** snapshot from public blind voting, where people pick the better answer without seeing which AI made it. The board for general text alone holds nearly 11 million votes. Tool stacks name the best approach to a job; the models powering them are the top-ranked ones. The tools will change next month. The rule will not.